

PEOPLE POWER

In an industry plagued by attrition, the average employee tenure at the logistics major remains at 10 years. What did the company do right?

By Arnab Dutta

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► **WHEN SUNJOY DHAAWAN**, Vice President of Human Resources, DHL Express (India), joined the logistics major in 2013, its business in India was limited to less than ₹3,000 crore in annual sales and women workers made up less than 10 per cent of its employee strength. Fast forward to now and DHL Express's annual revenue in India has grown to over ₹5,000 crore and the share of women employees has increased to 17 per cent—because of the consistent efforts that Dhaawan and his team have put in. And despite spending nine years with DHL, his tenure falls short of the firm's average tenure for an employee—which is 10 years now!

That pretty much sums up the company's success in managing its people—some 4,000 of them—in India. At a time when high attrition plagues most logistics and delivery companies and difficult working conditions of gig workers make news frequently, DHL Express has managed to not only retain talent but is also focussing on making its workforce diverse.

While the average attrition rate in the industry is around 14-15 per cent, at DHL the number is just 4-5 per cent. And at the level of frontline workers, it is even lower—at 2 per cent. This is in spite of the hiring spree all around, especially by e-commerce giants and the thousands of flourishing digital commerce start-ups. "If you look at the past 6-7 years, the Amazons and the Flipkarts of the world, or be it Snapdeal or Zomato... everybody else has hired hundreds and thousands of gig workers. But at DHL Express, the attrition rate in the past five years is less than 5 per cent. So, we are at a third of the industry. The reason why we haven't lost people to them [e-commerce and digital players] is because of the kind of connect that we have with our people, the engagement levels and the working conditions [that we provide]," says Dhaawan.

While poor working conditions, long hours and stressful situations haunt most gig workers in the country—leading to higher attrition and low job satisfaction—Dhaawan credits his company's unique position to its "four pillars". The first is the company's vision to become "the logistics company to the world". Second is its two guiding principles—respect and results—where respect for its employees and stakeholders comes ahead of the results it aspires to achieve. Third comes three building blocks that he calls the "three cornerstones of the company": "How can we be an employer of choice for our employees, an investor of choice for our investors and a provider of choice for our customers?" The fourth pillar is about motivating its people, which the manage-



Key HR initiatives

→ DHL Express (India) has managed to keep its attrition levels much lower than industry despite a hiring onslaught by e-commerce players

→ At 10 years, the average tenure of an employee at the logistics major is much higher than the industry

→ The company aims to become 'the logistics company to the world' by placing 'respect' (for employees) ahead of achieving 'results'

→ It has raised the share of women in the workforce by one percentage points each in last 3 years to 17 per cent. It aims to grow the share of women to 25 per cent by 2027, and to 40 per cent eventually